expected to resist a change if they felt that elections would bring in a government hostile to them. Suntook said:

Zia is apprehensive of parties like JSD cashing in on the prevalent discontent in the armed forces or of the politicians creating dissatisfaction within particular armed forces units like Bangladesh Lancers to further their own political aims. His efforts would, therefore, most probably be directed towards consolidating his position to a point where he can influence the type of government that comes into power and which would enable him to effectively remain in control behind this facade. The instability and indiscipline, if it continues, may provide him with a handy pretext for continuing the present authoritarian regime and martial law and postponing the elections to a time which he considers more favourable to his aims. With the present divisions within the armed forces themselves, it is unlikely that either Zia's group or his opponents would be in a position to organise a party on the lines of BSPP, but if Zia is able to eliminate the opposition, a development on those lines and Zia finally emerging as the civilian head of state cannot also be ruled out. The most likely structure that will emerge will be a political front party with the effective power in the hands of the armed forces. The emphasis and policy of the governments would be dependent on whether the freedom fighters or the repatriates finally predominate in the armed forces.

Suntook's assessment was crystal clear. The uncertainties in Bangladesh and the anti-India feelings were not easy to erase. Although there was a clear rift within Bangladesh, no potent force existed to challenge martial law and Zia's power. The Bangladeshi armed forces were divided into two camps—freedom fighters who had participated in the 1971 liberation